

Chapter One: Geographical Location of the Dinka

Introduction

The name Dinka is applied to both the language and its speakers - means “people.” Like the Nuer and the Masai, the Dinka are largely pastoral. The term “Dinka” was invented by outsiders and no one knows the origin of the word. The people now known as the Dinka actually call themselves Muonjang or Jieng. “The Dinka are a Nilotic people in the Republic of the Sudan. With a population nearly two million in a country of only fifteen million people and over five hundred tribes, they are by far the most numerous ethnic group in the Sudan. Also striking is their vast territory covering about a tenth of the nearly one million square miles that make the Sudan the largest country in Africa. To the nineteenth and even the mid-twentieth century travelers, the Dinka were better known as giants about seven feet tall who, like the Nile cranes, stand on one foot in the river for hours looking for fish.”¹ This was recorded before the independence of the Republic of South Sudan, and today Dinka still remain the largest tribe in South Sudan with an estimation of 4.5 to 5 million people with a vast land living along the Nile with the cattle. The Dinka have a distinct physical features of being tall and slim.

Dinka one of the most populous tribes in South Sudan and Sudan before the independence of the republic of South Sudan in 2011. “The majority of the Dinka in Sudan live in Bahr al Gazal and the upper Nile regions in the South, and the southern part of khordufan region in the north. The expansion of the Sudanese economy earlier, and war and famine recently, displaced large numbers of Dinka people, many of whom migrated to northern Sudan in search pf employment or to Ethiopia to seek

¹ Francis Mading Deng, *The Dinka of the Sudan*, New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston, 1972, 1.

refuge from war and famine.”² This focuses on the geographical location of the Dinka, their history and lifestyle throughout the history to date. The Dinka remain one of the most influential tribes in South Sudan because of their number compared to other tribes. “One linguist divides it into four dialects: Rek, Agar, Bor, and Padang.”³ and about twenty-five mutually independent tribal groups. But despite the heterogeneity among these sections, they remain united by their physical characteristics, their pride in being Dinka, and their remarkable cultural similarities. The most important of these similarities is the Dinkas love for cattle. They have numerous myths that explain their acquisition of, respect for, and devotion to cattle. Cattle provide the Dinka with much of their worldly needs.

“The Dinka, on the other hand, are a larger but less cohesive group than the Shilluks. Scattered from the river Sibat to the swamps of the Bahr al-Jabal and beyond to the tributaries of the Bahr al-Ghazal, the Dinka are a loose confederation of tribes who, in spite of their essential disunity and constant intertribal strife, have remained remarkably impervious to the language, religion, and customs of alien invaders. Like the Shilluks, they are renowned warriors, but their military effectiveness has been continually hampered by tribal divisions.”⁴ This explains the history of Sudan under the Turko-Egyptian Rule and especially the Mahdist revolution in Sudan in the 19th century. Bahr al-Ghazal was the first of the Egyptian provinces in the Southern Sudan to be affected by the Mahdist revolt. Its proximity to Kurdufan and Dar Fur, the heart of the Mahdist rebellion, made it a simple matter indeed for agents of the Mahdi to enter the province. This revolution made the like the Dinka, the Nuer, and the Shilluk,

² James Currey, *Ethnicity And Conflict In The Horn Of Africa*, Athens, Ohio University Press, 1994, 187.

³ Job Malou, *Dinka Vowel System*, Dallas, Summer Institute Of Linguistics, 1988, 1.

⁴ Robert O. Collins, *The Southern Sudan 1883-1898: A Struggle For Control*, New York, Yale University Press, 1962, 22.

who felt no kinship with the Arabs, joined the revolt not from religious fervor or feelings of brotherhood with the Northern Sudanese but rather to rid themselves of an oppressive and un-popular Government of the Turko-Egyptians.

Among the Nilotes “The Nuer and Dinka speak genetically related Western Nilotic languages that are derived from a common proto-language.”⁵ It is always good to differentiate between Nuer and Dinka though they share a lot among themselves and can rarely be noticed by an outsider. “Like the Nuer, their single-minded concern for cattle dominates their economic, social, religious, and aesthetic life; all activities revolve around the cattle camp and the seasonal migrations from the marsh lowlands in the dry season to the high ground in the wet.”⁶

1.1. Geographical Location

The Dinka are one of the largest ethnic groups in South Sudan. They belong to the Nilotic and specifically the River-Lake Nilotes. Today they are mainly found in most parts of the regions of Bahr el Ghazal, and some parts of Upper Nile and Jonglei State. This is to say they are found in six states out of ten and in two administrative areas out of three.

Historically, the Dinka trace their origins to the Nile Valley region. Scholars argue that they gradually migrated southward over many centuries before settling in their present homeland. Their oral traditions often speak of long movements in search of fertile land, water, and security. These migrations helped shape the Dinka identity and contributed to the spread of their culture across a wide area of South Sudan. Dinka

⁵ R.C. Kelly, *The Nuer Conquest : The Structure And Development Of An Expansionist System*, Michigan, The University Of Michigan Press, 1985, 9.

⁶ Robert O. Collins and Robert L. Tignor, *Egypt and The Sudan*, New Jersey, Prentice-Hall Inc., 1967, 17.

has an important part of the historical formation of Southern Sudan because of their number and courage gained from different experiences in life.

The Dinka have also experienced many challenges throughout their history. Colonial rule, civil wars, displacement, famine, and migration has affected their communities. These challenges helped the Dinka to move to different places to what is now South Sudan. However the Dinka don't live alone, but has neighbors like any other tribe would. Among the neighbors are the Nuer who are found in the Upper Nile region of South Sudan, Shilluk (collo) found in the areas of Malakal, Maban, Mundari bordering the Dinka Bor, among other unlisted tribes.

1.2. Sub-sections of the Dinka Tribe

1.2.1. Bor

Dinka Bor is one of the major sections of the Dinka tribe, the largest ethnic group in South Sudan. They inhabit the eastern banks of the White Nile in Jonglei State, with Bor town as their administrative and cultural center. Numbering several hundred of thousands, the Dinka Bor have played a pivotal role in the history of South Sudan, from the pre-colonial era through the civil wars to the present day, prominent figures in the liberation struggle for independence and prior to the independence. Dinka Bor section is one of the largest sections of the Dinka tribe, they historically comprise of Bor, Twii, Hol and Nyarweng as the recognized sections of the Bor Dinka, though with latest political divisions Twii and Nyarweng declaring themselves not being Dinka Bor, but this division still remains under scrutiny. The Bor Dinka are found in the South part of Upper Nile region and Jonglie state, they are referred to as the Southern Dinka because of their location in relation to the other Dinka. Dinka Bor

borders Mundari in central Equatoria, Aliap Dinka in Lakes State, Lou Nuer and the Murle in Pibor Administrative Area.

With the coming of the Europeans and demacation of their missionary activity “the Bor Dinka, on the Nile’s east bank, fell within the ‘CMS sphere.’ In contrast with the Rek, they have undergone considerable evolution in their religious concepts and institutions. Long subject to the disruption of merchants and military, they are somewhat more responsive to innovation than Western Dinka.”

1.2.2. Padang

“The earliest Dinka clans to arrive in Southern Sudan were those known today as the Padang (in Dinka the “place/land of Deng”) or “Northern Dinka.” They initiated their migrations out of the Gezira in a southward direction following the Nile River between the period after the fall of the Nubian king- dom of Alwa in the thirteenth century and the arrival of the Western Nilotic Shilluk at the Nile/Sobat tributaries in the latter fifteenth century. Presently, the Padang Dinka reside on the eastern bank of the Nile north and south of the Sobat, and also extend west across the Nile south of the Nuba mountains as far west as Abyei.” The Padang can be broken into twelve distinct groupings or sections and includes, Ageer, Nyiel, Aghol, Thoi, Rut, Atar, Abiliang, Ngok Lual Yak, Aloor, Panaruu and Ngok Kuol Deng.

They can easily be differentiated from the other Dinka through their accent when they speak although they themselves have minor accent differences, but above all they are have more similarities among themselves for instance traditional dances, marriage, bride price, and initiation among others.

Dinka Padang border Shilluk, Nuer and Maban from different sides of their allocated counties respectively. Dinka Padang are mainly found in Malakal and Renk Towns and Disputed Abiyei Administrative area.

1.2.3. Rek

Rek section of the Dinka are also known as the north western Dinka who also inhabit most parts of Bhar el Ghazal region of South Sudan. They are found in the major towns of Gogrial, Aweil and Tonj. Rek are the most numerous of all major Dinka groups in Southern Sudan today, comprising different sections. The Kuei reside from the modern-day towns of Tonj to western Gogrial. The Apuk reside from Tonj to east of Gogrial. Twic also known as the Twic Mayardit which separates them from Twic east, those found in Jonglie state and classified under the Dinka Bor Section. Malual is sub-section of the Rek who reside mainly in the current towns of Aweil bordering Sudan to the north. Agriculturally, Rek Dinka territory is not as fertile as that of the Agar, Ciec, and Gok to their south and southeast. At best the soils are muddy.

1.2.4. Agar

The Agar section of the Dinka tribe are sometimes known as the South western Dinka. History has that they recrossed the Nile to the western part. They are the immediate neighbours of the Dinka Bor who live on the eastern part of the Nile. Agar is further divided into sub-sections which includes Agar itself, Aliab, Ciec Manyiel, Pakam, and the Gok. "Agar today have four sections comprising the Rup, Kuei, Aliam Toc, and Pakam. Centuries ago the Agar migrated across the Nile from the east, some claiming to have come from as far away as Western Ethiopia, after forging south up the Blue Nile from central Sudan. Many of these folk eventually headed west and reaching the

Nile crossed to its western banks where they then separated. ‘Two priests led the people to their present area in the Bahr el-Ghazal: Rok Korec and Malwal Arop.’⁷

“Today the Ciec reside on the western banks of the Nile near the modern towns of Shambe and westwards toward Yirol. They comprise two major sections, the Ciec-Lou and the Ciec-Ador. These folk claim that, en masse, they acquired their name from the Dinka word for “bee,” for in the region of the Lou (Pagarou) there were many of these creatures. They believe that their ancestors resembled bees for they “were unified in searching for their own food.” The Dinka claim that the ancient father of all of the Ciec Dinka clans was Manyiel Tiop.”⁸

“The Aliab comprise four major sections: the Akuei in the west, the Apuk in the northwest, the Bulok in the southeast, and the Akeer in the north. The Aliab clans migrated from the Padang territory of the present-day Eastern Ngok Dinka region, proceeding southwards largely because of the need for good toic (grasslands) for their cattle. They found Bor Dinka already residing on the east bank of the Nile in their present position and following the Ciec they crossed the Nile westwards.”⁹ Each Aliab section was named after an event in history or by those who led them.

1.3. The Organization of the Dinka Tribe

1.3.1. Political Organization

Unlike societies that are ruled by kings or have centralized governments, the Dinka has a decentralized political system government. Their political organization is based mainly on clans, communities, elders, chiefs, age-sets, and previously on religious

⁷ Stephanie Beswick, *Sudan's Blood Memory: The Legacy of War, Ethnicity, and Slavery In Early South Sudan*, Rochester, University of Rochester Press, 2004,73.

⁸ Ibid, 65.

⁹ Ibid, 67.

leaders though some communities still have religious leaders even after Christianity was introduced. “Nilotic societies are lacking a centralized political authority, with social control operating through smaller local groups and relationships.”¹⁰ The leadership of the Dinka is practiced from the community level and not the subsections of the Dinka tribe itself, this explains that Dinka is a very decentralized community. Each clan has a considerable degree of independence in managing their own affairs without any interference, and in a clan there are sub-clans and families in which authority is shared among different leaders within each clan, sub-clan and family.

Dinka is like any other African tribe that is based on chiefdom and possess similar characteristics for instance the Nuer of South Sudan, who share a lot with the Dinka and having orally narrated common ancestry. The leadership in the Dinka is ranked from the paramount chief, chiefs, elders, youth leaders and the men in their houses.

Local chiefs play an important political role by maintain peace and order within their communities and represent their clans in negotiations with other clans when it is inter-clan dialogue, the paramount chief or the chief is always accompanied by group of elders well known as the council of elders. They help settle conflicts involving families, clans, cattle, land, and other resources. However, their power is not an absolute one but they work together with elders and other influential members of the community. In some clans of the Dinka tribe, chiefdoms are inherited once the chief dies, he is succeeded by his son, this is always announce to the community by the elders or the priest of the clan. Incase the chief has no son, the chiefdom is taken over by his immediate brother, this practice is not common to all Dinka sections or clans.

¹⁰ Evans-Pritchard, E. E., *The Nuer*, Oxford, Oxford University Press, 1940, 139.

Apart from being in the council together with the chief, the elders play an important role because of their age, experience, knowledge, and social status, makes them to be highly respected. They participated in making important decisions, settling disputes, and advising younger members of society. Their authority was generally based on respect and influence rather than the use of force.

“In colonial times, this Dinka attitude posed a problem for the British, whose policy of indirect rule was based on persuading local leaders to control their own territories on behalf of the administration. When the Chiefs of the Fishing Spear would not cooperate politically, the British were forced to work through the respected townsmen with whom they had direct contact, who then mediated between the world of the colonial administration and that of the tribes.”¹¹

“In dealing with political systems, therefore, we are dealing with law, on the one hand, and with war, on the other. When it comes to dealing with the law it pertains to the maintenance or establishment of social order, within a territorial framework, by the organized exercise of coercive authority through the use, or the possibility of use, of physical force. The well-organized states, the police and the army are the instruments by which coercion is exercised. Within the state, the social order, whatever it may be, is maintained by the punishment of those who offend against the laws and by the armed suppression of revolt.”¹²

¹¹ John Ryle, *Warriors of the White Nile: The Dinka*, Amsterdam, Time-Life Books, 1982, 153.

¹² M. Fortes And E. E. Evans-Pritchard, *African Political Systems*, London, Oxford University Press, 1940, Xiv.

1.3.2. Social Organization

1.3.2.1. Marriage

“In Dinka society, continuity of the lineage of the person is not only of primary importance, it is also sacred in the sense that it is fulfillment of the Will of God that the lineage of a person, whether male or female, is not allowed to become extinct. To marry not only fulfills an individual objective, but also discharges a social duty to the agnatic kin group. Since continuity through procreation involves the whole lineage, marriage is not simply a union of a man and a woman, but an alliance between their respective bodies of kin. This transforms the personal desire for marriage into a social obligation. Central to this system is the principle of perpetual identity and influence as expressed in procreation.”¹³

Dinka on the other hand practice different forms of marriage such as polygynous, levirate, and ghost marriage. Dinka society, like most African societies, is polygynous, and not polyandrous. This means that a man may marry more than one woman, but a woman must marry only one man. Levirate, commonly known as the practice of inheritance marriage, when the man dies or has aged and can no longer offer the conjugal right, a widow who is of childbearing age merely transfers her union in accordance with the practice of levirate, by which she lives with her husband's nearest agnate. This may be his eldest son. It may also be with the younger brother, nephew, or cousin of the dead man, this is done with the consent of the widow, she may agree to be inherited or not. This practice today is still common among the Dinka in all its sections. The third form of marriage that the Dinka practice is the ghost marriage, where by a male child that was in a particular family dies before the age of marriage, it becomes the responsibility of his brothers and cousins to marry for him, and if the

¹³ Francis Mading Deng, *Customary Law in the Modern World*, London, Routledge, 2010, 81.

decease is older than the one marrying for him then the first wife becomes that of the decease, and the younger marries after wards. This is not limited to only the deceased but also to man who couldn't bear a son who will become the heir of his family. This reveals the level of patriarchy in Dinka society. "Every Dinka fears dying without a son "to stand his head" to continue his name and revitalize his influence in this world. From the time a boy is born he is prepared for this role."¹⁴

"Capacity to marry is related to maturity and ability to procreate, which is determined by age. Traditionally, the Dinka have had no notion of age by years and there was therefore no fixed age when a person could marry. Among siblings, the older brother should marry before the younger, and sometimes the younger marries after the older has had a second wife. With half-brothers, the order is further determined by the seniority of their mothers."¹⁵

"There are also hindrances to marriage such as Blood relationship is an almost absolute bar; marital affinity prohibits marriage between a wide range of relatives-in-law; breast-feeding creates an exogamous bond between a child, the woman, and her children; and age-mateship and a special friendship pact bar intermarriage between the children or the siblings of the age-mates or the friends unless certain rites are performed. Marriage between feuding groups is also tabooed. Contravening these rules inflicts a curse on the mother and the children, causing a skin disease known as akeeth and maybe even death. The curse results from any sexual relationship, not only from marriage. Once confessed or divined, it may be repudiated by a ritual in which a ram is cut into halves symbolizing the severance of the relationship between the parties at the time of the act, but not justifying future behavior."¹⁶

Marriage implies loss of cattle as bridewealth, but it is also a means of acquiring cattle

¹⁴ Francis Mading Deng, *The Dinka of the Sudan*, 9.

¹⁵ Francis M. Deng, *Customary Law in the Modern World*, 85.

¹⁶ Francis Mading Deng, *The Dinka of the Sudan*, 92.

and an investment in anticipation of female offspring. People assist a bridegroom in the hope that he will beget daughters who will be married and reward them or their children with more cattle than they had paid. When marrying, Dinka use numerous cows to be given as bride price, which also varies from section to section among the Dinka, but ranges from 30 among the Dinka Bor but it can also exceed or decrease based on the agreement. A times it can exceed hundred cows especially it is a competition on who will take the bride, this practice is still common to date.

1.3.2.2. Family

Family comes as the result of marriage, and Marriage fulfils the obligation, the duty and the custom that every normal person should get married and bear children. This is believed to go back to the very beginning of human life. Failure to get married is like committing a crime against traditional beliefs and practices. “Children are greatly valued in African life. They are the seal of marriage. In many parts of the continent, once a marriage has produced children, it is very rare to see it broken up, since nobody wishes to part with his or her children. Children prolong the life of their parents, and through them the name of the family is perpetuated. Therefore children are the glory of the marriage.”¹⁷

Dinka families like any other African and especially Nilotic families are strictly extended families, it is very rare to find a nuclear kind of family in a Dinka setting. In Dinka setting of a family each of the member of the family has an important role to play in the family. The father in the house is the head of the family since Dinka is a patriarchal society, protector and provider of the family, the one that takes major decision of the family and he is the one that represents his family at the leve of the

¹⁷ John S. Mbiti, *Introduction to African Religion*, London, Heinemann, 1975, 108.

clan. The mother is mainly responsible for domestic responsibilities, and plays a very important of up bringing of the children though the man is involved but the greater part is done by the woman, she also teaches her daughters how to be respectful and become good women, since in the early Dinka girls are raised for marriage. “Children add to the social stature of the family, and both girls and boys have their social usefulness in the eyes of their families. They are taught obedience and respect towards their parents and other older people. They help in the work around the house and in the fields, in looking after cattle, fishing and hunting, building houses, going on errands, learning the trade or skills of their parents, and in many other ways.”¹⁸

1.3.2.3. Initiation

“Initiation is a public recognition that the individual is now passing from childhood to adulthood. As long as a person has not gone through initiation, he is regarded as a child. Therefore he is not given full responsibility at home and in the community.”¹⁹ Initiation is a central bridge in life. It brings together one's youth and adulthood, the period of ignorance and that of knowledge. Initiation is a crucial event that determines a man's status in Dinka society. It takes place between the ages of sixteen and eighteen and dramatically brings an end to childhood. “Initiation ceremonies give maximum value to courage, aggressiveness, and violence. Yet with this is a new demand: for a high degree of self-restraint, dignity of bearing, and responsible conduct must now be displayed. The most obvious attraction of initiation for youth is the dignity it gives a man. Until initiated, a young man is a “boy”. An uninitiated man may be sent on an errand at any time by any initiated man even though the latter may be younger. Uninitiated men are not permitted to sing except in children's

¹⁸ John S. Mbiti, *Introduction to African Religion*, 109.

¹⁹ Ibid, 94.

activities.”²⁰ Its really hard for a man who is not initiated to live among other young men, because he will always be treated unfair with an idea that he is still a boy. This makes his father to always be keen and when the season of initiation comes, he makes sure that his son is among those to be initiated. And if a man happens to marry before initiation he loses the respect he deserves from his wife, unless he does the ceremony of initiation.

1.3.2.4. Clan System

“The largest component of kinship is the clan, Wut, literally “cattle hearth,” an agnatic group composed of people descended from a common ancestor. The exact genealogical link may not be traceable. The intermediate ancestors may be confused or forgotten, and a jump of several degrees may be made to reach the alleged founder. Although the male line is more important, the female line is highly regarded. The totemic and exogamous requirements of clans are observed with respect to both the father s and the mother’s clans.”²¹

“The sub-clan, also called dhin in Dinka, is the fragment of the clan within which descent is accurately traced. The sub-clan may be fragmented into main lineages and sub-lineages.”²²

1.3.3. Economic Organization

“The Dinka practise a subsistence economy which is based on two major assets, animals and land. Animals are individually owned and the household as a unit makes it livelihood from the production of the animals owned by its members. The land is

²⁰ Francis Mading Deng, *The Dinka of the Sudan*, 68.

²¹ Francis Mading Deng, *Tradition and Modernization: A Challenge for Law among the Dinka of the Sudan*, London, Yale University Press, 1971, 6.

²² Laura Bohannan, *Tribes Without Rulers Studies in African Segmentary Systems*, Ed. Middleton And Tait, London, Routledge & Kegan Paul 1959, 105.

free but each ethnic group has the boundaries where its members claim the right for full utilization. Cultivation is round the homestead, while the intermediate land and the toich land that lie approximately due west towards the river are used for grazing.”²³

Though the Dinka groups retain the traditional pastoral life of Nilotes, they have added crop cultivation in some areas; growing peanuts, beans, and corn (maize). Women do much of the farming; men clear forests for cultivation sites. There are usually two plantings per year, a cultural practice that incorporates strategies for dealing with the annual cycle of one long dry season and one long rainy season. Women make pots and weave baskets and some men are blacksmiths, producing various implements for the community. They migrate regularly in response to the seasons and their agro-pastoral needs. Livestock, especially cattle, play a central role in Dinka culture and worldview. Traditionally, boys tend goats and sheep, while older men are responsible for the cattle.

“Cattle are a vital part of their society, and men often take on the name of their favorite cow. Cattle are prized not only as symbols of status but also for the milk and dairy products they provide as food. Their dung is used for fuel, and their urine is used as a disinfectant, possibly protecting the Dinka from disease and death. Beef is not generally eaten unless an animal has already died. Parts from the dead animal are used for many different things: hides for bedding; horns for snuff boxes, spoons, and trumpets; hooves for bells; and so forth. Cattle are used in bride-wealth payments at marriage and can easily reach 200 head.”²⁴ Especially when nicknaming Dinka

²³ Abdel Ghaffar M. Ahmed, *Anthropology in the Sudan: Reflections by a Sudanese Anthropologist*, Utrecht, International Books, 2002, 135.

²⁴ John A. Shoup, *The Nile: An Encyclopedia of Geography History and Culture*, California, ABC-CLIO LLC, 2017, 113.

prefers taking a name of his favourite bull, but when it is child naming ceremony the Dinka name mostly after the color of their cows, events at that particular time and the name of the grandparents.

A Dinka loves his cows so much that he is ready to die protecting them from any intruder. In the past Dinka won't give out his cow for anything else other than bride price or as a sacrifice not even for food unless it is sick or on special occasions that's when he will allow a cow to be slaughtered. Recently, with the exposure to the world, Dinka began trading with their cows as source of income by selling them rather than keeping them for bride and bride price alone.

1.3.4. Religious Organization

1.3.4.1. Believe in the Supreme Being

Dinka believe in a universal God called Nhialic who is the creator and source of life. "Nhialic is associated with the firmament and his name means literally 'in the above'. He is believed to have created the world and the established order of things. All the sections of Dinka believe in Nhialic as the *achieck* which means the creator."²⁵ Humans contact Nhialic through spiritual intermediaries and entities called *yath* and *jak* which can be appealed to through rituals.

Deng translated as lightening or rain is closely linked with Nhialic and there is some confusion in the beliefs concerning the relationship of the two. In some regions Deng is regarded as the supreme being and Nhialic is not mentioned, while in others Nhialic and Deng are believed to be the same spirit. Among the Dinka Bor, Nhialic and Deng are definitely regarded as two separate spirits. Dengdit may perhaps be regarded as an emanation or offspring of Nhialic, following the narrative of creation,

²⁵ Audrey Butt, *The Nilotes of the Sudan And Uganda*, London International African Institute, 1952, 130.

where Nhialic created everything and then rested after giving authority to Deng. Offerings are made to Dengdit at shrines scattered all over Dinka territory. It is he who sends rain from the sky.

1.3.4.2. Diviners

Among the diviners is Aiwel Longar a Spear-Master from whom Dinka trace their spear-masters from and especially the Dinka Bor though the story is common the other sections of the Dinka with narrative. Aiwel Longar has a mysterious story which is narrated as being born of an old widow whose husband was killed by a lion. “In bitter distress, she went to weep by the bank of the river. A Power of the river, Malengdit, I came to her and asked her why she wept, and when she said that it was because her husband was dead and she had no son, the Power called her to him in the river. He told her to lift her skirt, and to draw the waves [or the foam] towards her with her hand so that they might enter her. He then gave her a spear [which, carried by a woman, is a sign that she has borne a male child] and a fish to sustain her, and told her to go swiftly home, for she had conceived a son whom she would soon bear. The woman went home and bore a male child whom she called Aiwel. The child was born with its teeth complete.”²⁶ The name Longar came from the Bull that he owned when he took over the cattle of Jiel the husband of the Widow who became his mother.

Dinka have diviners such as the priests, rainmakers and medicine-men, who are found in every clan of the Dinka tribe. Priests among the Dinka are mainly concerned with maintaining the relationship between the community and God (Nhialic). They act as spiritual leaders who offer prayers and sacrifices on behalf of the people. During

²⁶ Godfrey Lienhardt, *Divinity and Experience: the Religion of the Dinka*, Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1961, 172.

important moments such as birth, initiation, marriage, or times of crisis like war or disease the priest leads rituals to seek protection, forgiveness, or blessing.

Medicine men often called healers focus more on health and misfortune. Among the Dinka, illness is not always seen as purely physical, it can have spiritual or social causes, such as broken relationships, curses, or displeasure of spirits. The medicine man diagnoses these problems and provides treatment using herbs, rituals, or protective practices.

Rainmakers play a vital role because the Dinka are traditionally pastoralists who depend heavily on cattle and seasonal rains. Without rain, there is no pasture, no water, and life becomes difficult. Rainmakers are believed to have special spiritual authority to call or control rain through rituals and prayers. During droughts, the community turns to them with great hope. Their role is not only practical but also symbolic, they represent the connection between human life and the forces of nature.

“To be human is to belong to the whole community, and to do so involves participating in the beliefs, ceremonies, rituals and festivals of that community. A person cannot detach himself from the religion of his group, for to do so is to be severed from his roots, his foundation, his context of security, his kinship and the entire group of those who make him aware of his own existence. To be without one of these corporate elements of life is to be out of the whole picture. Therefore, to be without religion amounts to a self- excommunication from the entire life of society, and African peoples do not know how to exist without religion.”²⁷

²⁷ John S. Mbiti, *African Religions and Philosophy*, Doubleday, New York, 1969, 3.

1.3.4.3. Rituals

Rituals among the Dinka are not just occasional ceremonies; they are part of everyday life and shape how people understand themselves, their community, and the world around. For the Dinka, ritual is deeply connected to their relationship with the divine Nhialic, their ancestors, and their cattle, which are central to their identity and survival.

“The act of sacrifice is not merely symbolic; it reflects the belief that the animal stands in place of the human being, carrying away misfortune, sin, or suffering.” The shrine is frequented by individuals suffering from domestic troubles, infant mortality, and sickness, and sacrifices are frequently made. The method of sacrifice is quite different from normal Dinka practice since the animal is not speared but is expertly cast, its throat being cut with a special spear kept for the purpose.”²⁸ Because cattle are the most valued possessions, offering them shows deep commitment and dependence on divine powers.” the act of sacrifice is accompanied by prayers and invocations, which are often performed together. The Dinka direct their prayers first to Nhialic, the supreme being, and then to other spiritual forces and ancestors. Other rituals naming and presentation of a new born child, initiation, marriage among others.

These rituals are administered by diviners and healers. While traditional practices are a strong component of Dinka belief systems, some Dinka people also practise Christianity or Islam. Muslim Dinka are common in the northern part of South Sudan bordering Sudan. Today majority of Dinka are Christians.

²⁸ Godfrey Lienhardt, *Divinity and Experience: the Religion of the Dinka*,

1.3.4.4. Ancestral Veneration

“The Dinka believe that every human being has a spirit and this they call atiep or tiep. The wandering of a person’s tiep during sleep is believed to account for dreams; moreover the tiep of a dead person may also appear in dreams and make certain demands on the living, such as requests for food and sacrifices. When a man or woman dies, every effort is made at the funeral ceremonies to propitiate the tiep and prevent a disgruntled ghost from sending sickness and misfortune. The spirit of a person recently dead is usually referred to as tiep but occasionally as Jok. The term Jok is normally reserved for the spirits of people who have long been dead and who may be reckoned as powerful ancestors.”²⁹

The spirit of the founder of a clan or of a lineage, and the spirit of the animal ancestor, are considered to be Jok. Both the Jok and the atiep make their habitations near the villages in which their descendants live. Jok are more powerful and energetic than atiep, and sometimes special shrines are built for them. Atiep are strongest immediately after death and funeral feasts are held to placate them lest they should bring sickness or death. They gradually grow weaker as they are forgotten but if they are important from the structural and social point of view, then they are remembered in legends and traditions and become Jok.

Conclusion

The Dinka of South Sudan present a highly integrated socio-cultural system in which geography, identity, and institutions are mutually reinforcing. History hasn’t recorded any violent separation among the Dinka despite their division into Rek Dinka, Agar Dinka, Bor Dinka, and Padang Dinka; reflects ecological adaptation and historical processes of expansion. At the structural level, Dinka society is organized around

²⁹ Audrey Butt, *The Nilotes of the Sudan And Uganda*, 131.

kinship, clan systems, and age-sets, which regulate social relations and cohesion. Politically, authority remains largely decentralized, grounded among the chiefs, and elders, whose legitimacy is grounded in customary law. Religiously, the Dinka worldview is centered on Nhialic, the supreme creator, alongside other spiritual forces and clan divinities. Cattle and the belief in Nhialic are the most uniting factors among the Dinka; though they vary in narrating their origin but their love and devotion for cattle and belief in Nhialic is all over the sections of the Dinka.